CYBER SAFETY GUY

SOCIAL MEDIA FOOTPRINT:

A PARENT'S PLAIN-ENGLISH GUIDE

Everything your child does online leaves a trace.
That trace is their digital footprint.
It can shape their future – for better or worse.
Here's what parents need to know.

81% of 13–17 year olds have posted something online others could see
Pew Research (2023)

70% of employers screen candidates online
CareerBuilder (2023)

7 YEARS of content can be found about the average person online
Swayable (2023)

1 WHAT IT IS
The trail of information you leave behind online.

2 HOW IT WORKS
Posts, likes, shares, searches and sign-ups add up. They stay, even if you delete.

3 WHAT'S INCLUDED
Posts, photos, videos, comments, likes, searches, tags, and location data.

4 WHO CAN SEE IT
Friends, strangers, future employers, schools, and more. Sometimes anyone.

5 WHY IT MATTERS
It can affect opportunities, reputation and personal safety.

6 CONVERSATION
Talk early.
Talk often.
Keep it open and judgement-free.

WHAT ADDS TO THEIR DIGITAL FOOTPRINT?

- **What they post** – Photos, videos, stories, updates.
- **What they engage with** – Likes, shares, comments, reactions.
- **What others post** – Tags, mentions, photos of them, check-ins.
- **What they search** – Search history can reveal a lot about them.
- **What they sign up for** – Apps, games, newsletters, competitions.
- **Where they go** – Location data from apps and check-ins.

WHAT PARENTS NEED TO UNDERSTAND

1. **It's hard to erase.** Once it's online, it can stick around.
2. **It follows them.** Their footprint can affect future jobs, college and opportunities.
3. **It can put them at risk.** Too much sharing can impact safety and wellbeing.

BY THE NUMBERS

60% of teens don't realise employers can see their online content
Kaspersky (2023)

35% of deleted content can still be found online
Digital Citizen (2023)

46% of teens have shared their location online
Pew Research (2023)

83% of recruiters say online content can influence hiring decisions
CareerBuilder (2023)

SAFETY SETTINGS: WHAT EXISTS vs WHAT TO CHANGE

WHAT EXISTS

- **Privacy settings** – Control who can see posts and info.
- **Content controls** – Limit who can comment, message or tag.
- **Location controls** – Turn off location sharing and check-ins.
- **Data controls** – Manage ad preferences and data sharing.

WHAT TO CHANGE

- Set accounts to private.
- Review followers and remove anyone they don't know.
- Turn off location sharing.
- Limit past posts and who can see them.
- Check third-party apps and remove access.

STEP-BY-STEP: PROTECT THEIR FOOTPRINT

1. **Check their presence.** Search their name together. See what comes up.
2. **Review privacy settings.** Make accounts private and limit sharing.
3. **Limit what they share.** Think before posting. Less is more.
4. **Think about tags.** Control who can tag them and what gets shared.
5. **Clean up regularly.** Delete old posts and unwanted content.
6. **Keep it going.** Revisit settings and have regular chats.

THE RISKS WORTH KNOWING

- **Oversharing** – Too much info can put them at risk.
- **Identity theft** – Personal details can be misused.
- **Reputation damage** – Old posts can cause future problems.
- **Cyberbullying** – Hurtful content can follow them.
- **Scams and grooming** – Strangers can use info to build trust.
- **Missed opportunities** – A negative footprint can close doors.

THE 10-MINUTE CONVERSATION

- What do you enjoy most about social media?
- What do you think people can learn about you from your posts?
- Is there anything you wouldn't want a future employer or teacher to see?
- If something goes wrong online, will you come to me?

TRUST OVER SURVEILLANCE
Connection builds safety.

IF THINGS GO WRONG

STAY CALM & GATHER EVIDENCE

- Stay calm and listen.
- Take screenshots or save links.
- Note the date, time and what happened.
- Don't delete anything.

REPORT & SEEK HELP

- Report to the platform.
- Block the person.
- Talk to a trusted adult.
- Get help from school if needed.
- Contact Childline for support.

★ You did the right thing. Help is available.

NEED TO TALK? CHILDLINE | **0800 1111** childline.org.uk | **YOU ARE NOT ALONE** We're here for you.